

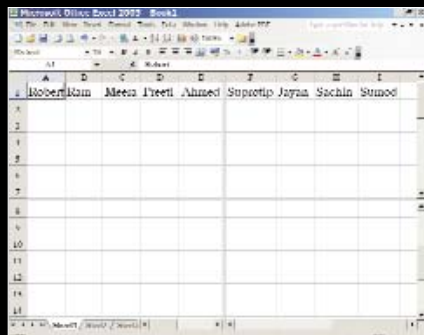
Microsoft Excel

Yes, we know Excel can be annoying. Here's how you can fix a few problem zones

1. Excel Freezes Columns While Freezing Rows

You have probably encountered this. Let's say your first row contains names, and you want to freeze the pane so the names are always displayed. You put the cursor at cell A1, and freeze the pane. What happens? Instead of just the first row freezing, some columns get frozen as well. What do you do?

Solution: Let's assume you need to freeze the top row, which contains, say, names. First, freeze the panes while at cell A1 by going to Window > Freeze Panes. Now, go to Window > Split. This will split the sheet into four blocks. Go to the centre of the split, so that the four-pronged cursor shows. Drag it up to the bottom of the row you want to freeze, and drag it also to the left, all the way, beyond the first column. Now, freeze panes again by going to Window > Freeze Panes. You are done!

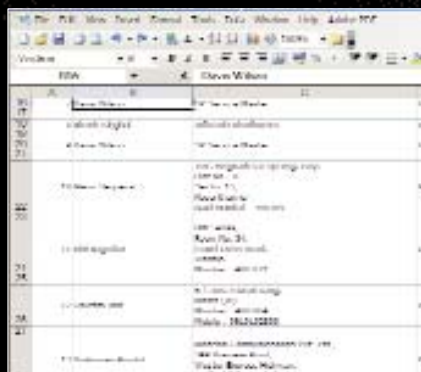


You need to split the sheet before you can properly freeze panes

2. All Cells Are Sized Differently

Say you have a mixed workbook—one column contains five-line addresses, one contains single-line numbers, and so on. You will have cells of various sizes. It doesn't look pretty. When you highlight a cell that has a lot of text, the contents show up from the formula bar in a yellow box, obscuring everything underneath it.

Solution: Here's how you change all the cells in a range to be the same size. Say you are doing it row-wise. You will want to adjust the height of the columns in this case. Place the cursor on a particular row number: the cursor should change to a



Before: The text boxes are all different sizes, and scrolling is clumsy

horizontal arrow. Now drag the cursor down to cover the range you need. Then, place the cursor on a row boundary to the left of the cells and stretch it to the height you want the columns to be. All cells you selected will now be of the same height.

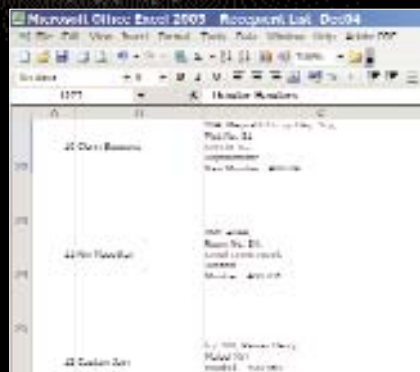
3. The Annoying "Getting Started" Pane

When you start Excel 2003, what you get instead of a nice blank sheet is the sheet on the left, with the "Getting Started" pane on the right. All along, you have just been closing it after starting Excel. Besides, you probably don't need it.

Solution: To prevent the Task Pane from popping up, go to Tools > Options, and select the View tab. Un-tick "Startup Task Pane." That should do it. If it doesn't, open the registry editor. Navigate to this key: HKEY_CURRENT_USER\Software\Microsoft\Office\11.0\Common\General. Right-click the "DoNotDismissFileNewTaskPane" key, and then click Delete. Click OK to confirm that you want to delete the key. This should prevent the Task Pane from popping up, if the first method didn't work.

4. Credit Card Numbers Show Up Chopped Off At The End

You would have encountered this if you have worked with credit card numbers: you enter a number such as "5458004513024384", and it shows up as "5458004513024380"—with the last digit changed to a zero. It might even have



After: When you resize all cells to be the same size, it looks nicer, and scrolling feels better

happened without your noticing it, and you might be dealing with wrong data! The reason this happens is that Excel cannot handle integers more than 15 digits long.

Solution: To fix the problem, either append an apostrophe before the card number to mark it as text, or manually format the cells as text.

5. Numbers And Dates Go Awry

In some instances, you might find that when you copy a range of dates from one workbook and paste them onto another, all the dates are off by four years—for example, "10/12/2004" becomes "10/12/2008". Another irritating thing about dates is that when you subtract one date from another to find the number of days between them, the result shows up as a date that you do not recognise.

In some instances, when you type a number, for example, "23", it becomes "0.23" even if you have formatted the cell without decimals.

Solution: To fix the four-year date problem, go to Tools > Options, then click the "Calculation" tab. Make sure the "1904 date system" box is un-ticked. To make the results of date calculations appear correctly, you'll need to manually format the result cell as a number.

For the latter problem, go to Tools > Options, and in the "Edit" tab, un-tick "Fixed decimals". ■

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